The best the US ambassador to India could report, however, was that Connally's meetings had "helped to clear the atmosphere at least to some degree."[305] Less than a month later, Keating reported back a "profoundly disturbing" farewell meeting during which Gandhi asserted, "everything the US does is against India."[306] By late August, a frustrated Jha was telling Kissinger's deputy Al Haig, "The present state of Indo-American relations could well have provided the plot for a farce by Molière."[307]

The public and private Indian antipathy was heightened by the continued sense that China and the US were colluding to contain India, with Pakistan as an instrument. Gandhi's *Foreign Affairs* article highlighted the dispatch of the USS *Enterprise* and the "extraordinary similarity of attitudes adopted by the United States and China" during the Bangladesh crisis. It noted that the American approach toward the Soviet Union and China was wise, but expressed concern that it could adversely affect India's interests. The article provided as an example Sino-US cooperation in the UN Security Council.[308]

Subsequently, Jha reiterated to Kissinger India's concerns about the extent to which US "cultivat[ion]" of China would "encourage China to conduct a certain policy detrimental to our interests." The US national security adviser explained that Beijing was concerned about India because of its fear of the Soviet Union. He admitted that the US "would not do something deliberately to affront China when China feels its security directly threatened." Beyond that, he asserted, "In the normal conduct of diplomacy, we see no reason to coordinate our policy with China." Kissinger insisted that the question of improvement of US-India relations was "totally independent of China." He added, "If China engaged in military adventures against India, we would not support it at all. Our attitude on that has not changed at all."[309]

Given the 1971 experience, Kissinger's credibility on this front was not high in Delhi. It would have been even lower had Indian policymakers known that during Kissinger's June trip to China, he had made a commitment to give Beijing "more detailed information on Indian armed forces, tank production, etc. through [a] private channel."[310] Furthermore, his list of the outstanding commitments to China included that the US would consider supplying Pakistan with arms that China could not, and would consult with China regarding any "major change" in America's South Asia policy.[311]